Speech at Wheeling, West Virginia

Sen. Joseph R. McCarthy (R-WI) · February 9, 1950 · widely-reprinted version

Source: Joseph R. McCarthy, speech at Wheeling, West Virginia (Feb. 9, 1950), prepared text entered in the Congressional Record, via Teaching American History (its editorial cuts are shown as . . .). Public domain.

Joseph McCarthy was a then-obscure first-term senator when he addressed a Republican women's club in Wheeling. He held up a paper he claimed listed 205 Communists working in the State Department. The exact number shifted over the next several speeches — 205, 57, 81 — and the original text was never preserved verbatim. The Wheeling speech launched four years of McCarthy hearings, Senate investigations, and the broader Red Scare known as 'McCarthyism.'

Connect: The Second Red Scare produced blacklists, loyalty oaths, and reputation destruction. Compare the atmosphere of 1950-54 to the Alien and Sedition Acts era (Class 7). What repeats?

Key Passages

The framing of the global struggle

Today we are engaged in a final, all-out battle between communistic atheism and Christianity. The modern champions of communism have selected this as the time, and ladies and gentlemen, the chips are down – they are truly down.

The enemy within

The reason why we find ourselves in a position of impotency is not because our only powerful potential enemy has sent men to invade our shores – but rather because of the traitorous actions of those who have been treated so well by this Nation. … This is glaringly true in the State Department. There the bright young men who are born with silver spoons in their mouths are the ones who have been most traitorous.

The claim

I have here in my hand a list of 205 – a list of names that were made known to the Secretary of State as being members of the Communist Party and who nevertheless are still working and shaping policy in the State Department.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Second Red Scare: the Soviet atomic bomb, the fall of China to communism (1949), the Alger Hiss case, and rising fear of communist spies in government.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	A Republican women's club in Wheeling, and through the press, the American public and the Truman administration.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Joseph McCarthy, an ambitious Republican senator who used anticommunism for political gain; those he accused had no chance to respond.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Sourcing — HIPP for 3 McCarthyism docs (1 pt): Write one sentence each on Historical situation, Intended audience, Purpose, and POV for this speech.
2. Why was a senator like McCarthy able to make sensational claims with no evidence and gain national traction?
3. What ended McCarthy's power — and when?